

The Silence of the Deans

In December 2013 the President of the University of Saskatchewan called a meeting of the Senior Leadership Team (Deans and Vice-Presidents) to discuss the TransformUs process. Her remarks were to the point: she expected her senior leaders to not “publicly disagree with the process or findings of Transform Us”; she added that if we did our “tenure would be short.” With that meeting there was the ‘silence of the deans’. Never in my 40 years of academic life have I seen academics being told that they could not speak out and debate issues. Although the initial publicly released TransformUs documents were vague, behind closed doors the President and Provost planned major changes to our School of Public Health, all the while warning me against discussing any of these proposals with my faculty and students. Deans were also told that when the final recommendations were released we had to support them with faculty, students and the public, even if we disagreed with them. Immediately before the release of the documents detailing what would happen to the School I was cautioned again by the Provost in an email (see Attachment #1) that the President expected me to support University messaging.

I came to the University of Saskatchewan in 2009, after working as a professor of Public Health for 35 years, as the founding Executive Director of the School of Public Health. My mission was to build one of the finest Schools of Public Health in Canada. With the support of faculty, staff and students the School’s enrolment grew from 17 to 238 with the largest international student body of any SPH in Canada and for five years we all worked hard to have the School’s MPH program accredited. In January 2014 the School became the first School of Public Health in North America to have their Masters of Public Health Program accredited by the Agency for Public Health Education Accreditation (APHEA). However, the letter granting accreditation cautioned that “when an accredited programme undergoes a substantive change it is obligated to provide written notification to APHEA.” (See Attachment #2.)

Much of what has been built over the last 5 years is threatened by the TransformUs plan to place the School of Public Health under the College of Medicine. Colleges of Medicine focus on treating illness, while Schools of Public Health emphasize prevention of disease. That is why since the 1960s the trend across North America has been clear: successful Schools of Public

Health have become independent of medical schools. There are 3 questions that I have consistently asked the President and Provost that have not been adequately answered:

- 1) Why would the President want to put a successful School of Public Health, with a newly accredited MPH Program, under the College of Medicine which is struggling and on probation?
- 2) Why would the President want to ask the University Council to reverse its decision made in 2007 after significant study and debate to create an independent School of Public Health (the idea of putting the School of Public Health into the College of Medicine was considered and rejected at that time)? (See Attachment #3.)
- 3) Why would the President want to jeopardize our recently won accreditation since the letter granting accreditation makes it clear that any substantive change would trigger a review of the program?

In response to my questions, the President and Provost have cited the need to reduce the number of deans and number of structures and agencies. It is bewildering how such considerations could trump arguments based on sound academic evidence.

Major changes with long term ramifications have been planned behind closed doors, with little or no opportunity for faculty or students to respond. The major recommendations have been released in May when some of our faculty and most of our students are not even on campus.

What the University needs is leadership and courage. When members of University Council are asked to reverse their decision to create an independent School of Public Health I hope they will carefully review the evidence, listen to the views of affected faculty and students and hold a secret ballot vote before they make this and other important decisions. Hopefully, the Board and the province's political leaders will ask probing questions and ensure that due process is followed. University autonomy is important but so is having open and free debate.

As my 5 year term draws to a close I want to thank my academic colleagues for their support and the people of Saskatchewan for their warmth and hospitality.

From: Provost & VP Academic
Sent: Tuesday, April 29, 2014 1:03 PM
To: Buckingham, Robert; Sutherland, Ken
Cc: Phillipson, Martin; Uswak, Gerry; Smith, Colum; Muzychka, Ivan; Germida, Jim
Subject: TransformUS communications

Buck and Ken,

As we head into an active phase of TransformUS communications, I am thinking particularly of the two of you. You are in an especially tough position and are subject to the expectation the president has of all leaders, that you will support TransformUS and the university's messaging.

My expectation is that there will be no mention in public or to government that changes to our internal structures will endanger anyone's accreditation. Such statements would be premature in many ways – first because we do not know of any such certain impacts, and second because (as we have discussed) we are launching projects (not decisions) that will include the opportunity for you, faculty, students, and staff to propose any other solutions that are equally good for meeting the university's goals in TransformUS. It is important for leaders of our community to uphold the university's autonomy and its right to make its own decisions whether or not we individually agree with them. Conversations about university structures belong in the university.

As I say, I am thinking of you and will be glad to support your communications and your constructive leadership of your faculty and students in any way I can. I am sure others I have copied on this message will join me in that offer.

Brett

Attachment # 2



Dr. Robert Buckingham
Director
School of Public Health
University of Saskatchewan
107 Wiggins Road
Saskatoon, SK S7N 5E5
Canada

January 7th, 2014

Dear Dr Buckingham,

On behalf of the Agency for Public of Public Health Education Accreditation, I am pleased to inform you that the Board of Directors acted to accredit the following programme for a five year term extending to December 31, 2018: Master of Public Health.

Enclosed is a copy of the final site visit report. The next review will include assessment of the extent to which the programmes have come into compliance with the recommendations given concerning the sub-criteria which were 'not met', 'partially met' or 'met with comments' which additionally form an addendum to this letter.

APHEA staff will be in touch with you approximately two years prior to the expiration of the accreditation period. Please note that when an accredited programme undergoes a substantive change it is obligated to provide written notification to APHEA. Substantive changes generally include adding or discontinuing an area of specialisation, changing the format of a degree programme and making major revisions to curricular requirements.

Once again, we greatly appreciated the many courtesies extended to the site visit team during the visit. Please contact APHEA staff should you have any questions. They will be pleased to assist you.

Thank you for your cooperation.

Yours sincerely,

Antoine Flahault
President, APHEA Board of Directors

UNIVERSITY OF SASKATCHEWAN



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SCHOOL OF PUBLIC HEALTH

Proposal to University Council

9 May 2007

Prepared by the School of Public Health Steering Committee:

William Albritton, Health Science Deans Committee
Allan Backman, Commerce
Shawna Berenbaum, Pharmacy and Nutrition
Bryan Bilokreli, Integrated Planning Office
Lawrence Brawley, Kinesiology
John Campbell, Western College of Veterinary Medicine
Roy Dobson, Pharmacy and Nutrition
James Dosman, Canadian Centre for Health and Safety in Agriculture (CCHSA)
Pauline Melis, Integrated Planning Office
Nazeem Muhajarine, Medicine
Cordell Neudorf, Saskatoon Health Region
Andrew Potter, Vaccine and Infectious Disease Organization (VIDO)
Bruce Reeder, Medicine (Special Advisor)
James Spinney, Integrated Planning Office
Lynnette Stamler, Nursing (Chair)
Hugh Townsend, Western College of Veterinary Medicine and VIDO
Gerry Uswak, Dentistry
Matt Webster, Financial Services Division

2. Epidemiology - distributions and determinants of disease, disabilities and death in human and animal populations; the characteristics and dynamics of populations; the natural history of disease; and the biologic basis of health.
3. Environmental health sciences - environmental factors, including biological, physical and chemical factors, which affect the health of a community;
4. Health services administration - planning, organization, administration, management, evaluation and policy analysis of health programs; and
5. Social and behavioral sciences - concepts and methods of social and behavioral sciences relevant to the identification and the solution of public health problems

Furthermore, as noted in the Task Force on Changing Structures Discussion Paper on a School of Public Health (April 10, 2006), it must be independent from the professional colleges:

"The School of Public Health is best positioned in the university as an academic entity equivalent to, but separate from, the professional health science colleges. This would not only promote the necessary interdisciplinary research and teaching environment, but is required for accreditation by the North American accrediting body, the Council on Education for Public Health"

5.2 Leadership

The School of Public Health will be led by an Executive Director. Since the Executive Director will function in a manner similar to that of a Dean, it is desirable that this position be out-of-scope. Rather than negotiating a change to the collective agreement, it is proposed that the head of the School be appointed as an Executive Director by means of the same process as for decanal appointments. Like other College Deans, the Executive Director of the School of Public Health will report to the Provost. The Executive Director will be a member of the University Deans' Council, Health Science Deans' Committee, and the Inter-professional Health Science Office.

In providing leadership to the School, the Executive Director will be assisted by an Executive Committee, the composition of which might include the Chair of the Graduate Program Committee, the Chair of the Research Committee, elected members of the SPH Faculty Council, directors of the research units located within the School, and a representative from the Health Science Deans Committee. Upon the establishment of the School, a Resource Management Committee will be formed to negotiate and oversee faculty appointments during the inaugural period. Membership on this committee could include the Executive Director, the Executive Sponsor (Vice-Provost), and the participating Health Science Deans (Figure).